

A Practical Study of PHILIPPIANS

THE GOAL OF CHRISTIAN LIVING “Important Keys to Successful, Fulfilled Living”

GOAL NUMBER THREE – THE SUFFERING OF CHRIST – PHILIPPIANS 1:27-30

The first two studies we’ve looked at were:

1. The Love of Christ and
2. The Glory of Christ

The ultimate goal and objective is to cooperate with the Father’s plan to make us like Jesus Christ.

There are secondary goals to that full accomplishment and we need to recognize them:

1. Be an instrument for the LOVE of Christ to flow through us.
2. Live for His GLORY and not for our own, that Christ might be seen in us.
3. Make SUFFERING a goal for our life.

It's only when we really suffer for something that it takes on meaning and it declares to the world that it means something to us.

The early disciples came out of an experience of being told they weren't to preach anymore, rejoicing in the fact that they had the privilege of suffering for the cause of Christ.

Hyde, who was a communist for a number of years, wrote probably one of the best books on leadership. The book is called *Dedication and Leadership*. He takes us behind the communist cause to show us why they're shaking the world in coming close to world-wide domination. He says this:

(Dedication and Leadership by Douglas Hyde)

Communism becomes the dominant thing in the life of the Communist. It is something to which he gives himself completely. Quite obviously, it meets a need, fills a vacuum at the time when he is first attracted to it. More significant is that it normally continues to be the dominant force in the life of the Community for as long as he remains in the movement. They work on the assumption that if you call for big sacrifices, people will respond to this and moreover the relatively smaller sacrifices will come quite naturally. I have just got to join the party. I have had no excuse apart from my own desire for a quiet life and my own laziness and selfishness for not joining for a long time now. I have known that, that it is where I really belong. But now, in this situation, I could not live with

myself if I did not join. I am ready now to make the sacrifices which will be demanded of me.
(source unknown)

We have to a “come on” mentality:

“You come on now. Do God a favor by accepting the gift of His Son and you’ll have pie-in-the-sky by and by and you can have health-wealth-and prosperity until you get there so it’s a piece of cake. You can just really enjoy yourself. We wouldn’t want to ask you too much but if you feel like it some Sunday, you might want to give a little money to support the program. And you can show up any time you want. You just come. You’re really doing God a favor when you get your family organized. And you get over there in time for church for service. We really wouldn’t want too much demand on you.”

(source unknown)

That’s the kind of stuff we’re preaching. We don’t see that in the New Testament. Men and women so consumed with the passion of Jesus Christ that nothing is more important than their relationship to Him and it's a dominant force in their lives.

Jesus was right when He said: “If any man will come after me, you’re going to pay a price. Deny yourself and take up your cross and follow me.” (Luke 9:23 paraphrase)

Paul said it well in Romans 8:18. This is the marathoners' verse when he hits the wall.

Romans 8:18

I consider that the sufferings of this present time are not worthy to be compared with the glory that's going to be revealed in us later.

The apostle could say that's it.

John Hunter and Ian Thomas traveled around the United States, speaking a lot on Christ living in us. Hunter wrote a book called *Living the Christ-Filled Life*. In it he says:

(Living the Christ-Filled Life by John Hunter)

So many people play at being Christians, dressing up for the part, learning their words, correcting their exits and entrances, so that as they strut on the world's stage, they play their part very well. They become good actors. But when the costliness of the Christian life is considered, they shrink from the consequences. Someone has said that concerning the Christian life, the entrance charge is nothing but the annual subscription is everything.

(source unknown)

Howard Hendricks wrote a book called *Don't Fake It: Say It With Love*. He says:

(Don't Fake It: Say It With Love by Howard Hendricks)

Recently I ran across a quotation that stabbed me. "There was never a feast without a sacrifice." This was true for Christ who came not to be ministered unto but to minister, and to give His life a ransom for many. It is also true for believers who die to themselves so that they can bear fruit to the hungry souls of the world.

(source unknown)

Jesus says He spoke to those who longed to see Him:

John 12:24, 25

...Unless a grain of wheat falls into the ground and dies, it abides alone. But if it dies, it bears much fruit. He who loves his life loses it, and he who hates his life in this world shall keep it to life eternal.

This first chapter has three secondary goals, built one upon the other, and they cannot be reversed.

You are not ready to suffer for someone until you really love them.

You are not ready to make a commitment in your marriage relationship for life, to suffer with that mate, until you really, really have learned to love them.

When you really love someone, you want their glory more than anything else. That is your purpose. Then you're ready—even if possible, or necessary—to lay down your life.

Jim Elliot who died as a martyr in Ecuador said:

He is no fool who gives what he cannot keep to gain what he cannot lose.

(source unknown)

That's the expression of someone who, with the love of Christ compelling him, living for the glory of Christ, is willing now to suffer for Him.

We're going to talk about suffering from a totally different perspective. It's not just the health, wealth and prosperity, but it's this whole faith healing movement that demands a clear physical health—a vibrant, dynamic, physical temple—that's supposed to be a foregone conclusion for believers.

We have a lot of bitter and resentful hangers-on in the body of Christ today who don't experience that. As a result, they've been left outside, not wanting to associate or fellowship because they don't fit.

We only have 3 verses—beginning at verse 27.

v. 27 Only live as citizens in a manner worthy of the gospel of the Christ; in order that whether having come and having seen you or whether being absent,

I am hearing things concerning you, that you are standing firm in one spirit, contending with one soul for the faith of the gospel;

“Only live as citizens in a manner worthy of the gospel of Christ; in order that whether having come and having seen you or whether being absent, I am hearing things concerning you, that you are standing firm in one spirit, contending with one soul for the faith of the gospel;”

Now that he’s talked about love and glory, he says “Please ‘live as citizens in a manner worthy of the gospel.’ Remember whose you are. Remember who you represent. Steadfastness in the difficult places is what I delight in.”

The early Christians, as they pointed themselves toward the roaring beasts who were ready to take their lives, would say, “That is not hard to be steadfast when the roaring beasts are coming at you. It’s just being steadfast on a daily basis, in the day-in, day-out frustrations of life”

Nothing is more thrilling to heaven than seeing a soldier who’s gone out to battle early in the day but then to see him still standing his ground late in the afternoon.

God delights in those who, with steadfastness and stability, are demonstrating Jesus Christ is alive and He’s totally adequate to meet our needs.

1 Corinthians 16:13

Keep your eyes open for spiritual danger. Stand true to the Lord. Act like men. Be strong.

That's what it means to live as a citizen who's worthy.

Phillips in his paraphrase sometimes captures it more beautifully than we can even get it as we just read it word-for-word in the Greek text. He says:

Make sure that your everyday life is worthy of the gospel of Christ.
(source unknown)

People aren't impressed by what we believe but they're more impressed by what we are.

Our Christian confession must issue in Christian living or it is sound and fury, signifying nothing.

There are so many verses in the scripture that describe that well.

Colossians 2:6

As you have therefore received Christ Jesus, the Lord, so walk ye in Him.

1 John 2:6

The one who says he abides in Him, ought himself also to walk in such a manner.

Luke 6:46

The Lord says “Why call ye me Lord, and you do not the things which I say?”

What is the purpose behind that? See the next phrase?

“live as citizens”—that’s a **COMMAND**.

What’s the **PURPOSE**?

“in order that whether I come and I see you or whether I’m absent, I am going to hear about it.”

We want to know whether we see it or hear it, that our life bears up under close scrutiny. That we’re living as citizens—people—who are a credit to the cause of Jesus Christ.

That next phrase is taken out of the Roman amphitheater:

“...that you are standing firm in one spirit...”

This is a group of Christians that has been taken into the Roman amphitheater and they’re ready for their flesh to be eaten.

He says when you get in that kind of situation, don't anybody turn and run! All of you stand together because you're great witness at that time is to "stand firm in one spirit."

Ephesians 6:13

Use every piece of God's armor to resist the enemy whenever he attacks. And when it's all over, you will still be standing up.

Suffering in our lives ought to bring us together. It ought to cause us to get close and to stand firm, one with the other.

It's going to be interesting to hear the Lord's initial remarks about the condition of the body of Christ today.

We read in John 17 His prayer. He prayed that they'd be one, even as we are one. Yet we see such a fragmented fighting body—believers going in every direction.

It was the Lord's desire that we would be one in our faith and we would stand united, first together and united in our efforts, singing:

*Bless be the tie that binds
Our hearts in Christian love.*

Now look what he says. This is the third thing in this verse:

1. "live as citizens in a manner worthy,"

2. “stand firm in one spirit,”

3. “contend with one soul for the faith of the gospel.”

You have your DEFENSE and your OFFENSE there.

Your DEFENSE is to “stand firm.”

Your OFFENSE is to “contend.”

1 Corinthians 15:58

Therefore, my beloved brethren, be ye steadfast,
unmoveable...

“Standing firm” means we have our SHIELD OF THE FAITH ready to catch all the fiery darts of the wicked one.

We’re “contending” with the SWORD OF THE SPIRIT, which is the Word of God. We’re fighting a good fight, using the scriptures.

Elisabeth Elliot, the wife of Jim Elliot who died in 1956, wrote a book called *Discipline: The Glad Surrender*. She says this:

(Discipline: The Glad Surrender by Elisabeth Elliot)

Is there any image of freedom and joy more exhilarating than a full orchestra, everybody sawing, tootling, pounding,

strumming, blowing, clashing, and hammering away for all they are worth, under the direction of the immense energy and discipline of a man who knows every note and every instrument in the concerto, and knows how to elicit that note exactly so that it will contribute most fully to the glory of the work as a whole.

(source unknown)

That's what God wants when He looks down! We're tooting our trumpet and playing our violin. We're standing together and we're being orchestrated by the divine orchestra Master who knows everything! Who knows every note that needs to be played, every person whose life needs to be touched! Together we can contend for the cause of Christ.

The apostle doesn't paint any pretty picture here of coming to know Jesus and doing Him a favor and then sitting down and enjoying health, wealth and prosperity.

The picture he paints here is one of fighting for our lives, standing together, united in cause and purpose, playing the score that the Lord has left for us to play.

What are we going to do when we get harassed from without?

v. 28 and in no way being intimidated by your opponents, which is to them clear evidence (proof) of utter destruction, but of your salvation, and this from God.

“and in no way being intimidated by your opponents, which is to them clear evidence (or proof) of utter destruction, but of your salvation, and this from God.”

“no way intimidated by your opponents...”

1 Samuel 28:5

When Saul saw the camp of the Philistines, he was afraid and his heart trembled greatly.

That’s so different from David with a sling-shot and five rocks. “The battle is the Lord’s! Let me at him! I’ll hit him between the running lights! Boy, we’ll drop this big dude.”

When playing sports the other team can be intimidating. You have to learn to concentrate on your training. If you’re intimidated, you’ve already lost the game. If you get scared before you get on the court, you might as well pack your bags and head to the house. You’re going to lose.

Paul is saying when you get in the trenches and when they’re firing at you and it hurts—stay with the stuff and don’t be intimidated by those who are throwing all the flack. Don’t be frightened in any way.

The word “intimidated” is the word that’s used to describe a horse that’s been spooked. If you get your horse spooked you realize that you’re experiencing some of the very same things that are described here in the text.

Proverbs 29:25

The fear of man brings a snare, but whosoever puts his trust in the Lord shall be saved.

2 Timothy 1:7

God has not given us the spirit of fear but of power and of love and of a sound mind.

Remember the children of Israel? They come up to the land with all the promises of God that the land was theirs. Moses made a big mistake. Instead of trusting God and going on in, he forms a committee. Every time you do that, you're going to get in trouble.

Here's a great little statement:

God so loved the world that He didn't send a committee!
(source unknown)

That just fits.

"We must have one from each of the twelve tribes go in here and check it out. See if we can take it."

When you have a committee, you have a majority minority report. You're not going to get unanimity in anything.

When they come back there are 10 guys that say, “we’re like grasshoppers and they’re giants.”

Only two guys—Joshua and Caleb—were ready for the fight.

They were incredible individuals. It’s said of Caleb: “he wholly followed the Lord.” He finally says, “give me this mountain! God and I’ll drive the giants out of there! I’m ready for a new battle and a new fight.”

He’s the epitome of retirement by the way—from the biblical perspective. You never see him stopping till it’s all over.

For David it’s “the battle is the Lord’s.” As a result he wins!

In 2 Chronicles 20 Jehoshaphat gets the word they’re coming from the east, they’re coming from the west, they’re coming from the north! He drops on his knees in prayer and says: “Oh God, we don’t have any might against this great company but our eyes are upon you! Lord, the next move is yours!”

Do you know what God said? “Send the choir out. And as soon as the choir starts singing the battle is going to be won. Don’t worry about it. It’s not your battle to fight. I’m going to take care of it.”

And God does! Corpses dropping everywhere as the choir begins to sing. That’s the way God does things.

He said:

Matthew 10:28

Fear not them which kill the body but are not able to kill the soul. But rather fear him who is able to destroy both soul and body in hell.

We get scared, don't we? We get intimidated. But don't give in!

Someone said "There is no armor for the back."

God designed it that way! If we don't have our shield up there in front, it's going to hit us when you turn and run! Stay with the stuff.

1 John 4:18

There is no fear in love but mature love casts out fear because fear has punishment. He that fears is not made perfect in love.

"...which is to them clear evidence (proof) of utter destruction..."

The fact that they're fighting against God is an indication that the day's coming when it's going to be utter destruction for them. They're fighting God's purpose in what they're doing.

Romans 8:31

If God be for us, who can be against us.

2 Corinthians 2:14

Thanks be to God, who is always leading us in triumph in Christ...

“...but of your salvation, and this from God.”

That wonderful salvation is going to be accompanied with suffering.

The reason older people have such a hard time is they’ve never been taught a proper concept of suffering. So when it happens and their body starts to fall apart, they really can’t relate effectively because they’ve never learned that suffering relates to the Christian life.

We’re all going to fall apart. The wheels are going to come off and we’re going to lay on that bed and somebody’s going to have to come and wait on us and we’re going to die.

Now it’s cool to put that out of your mind right now and just have it all together and not suffer a day! But none of us are exempt!

Let’s take suffering out of the arena of the devil and let’s take suffering out of the arena of God punishing us for something in our lives. Let’s put it as positive—as a tool, as a goal, as an

objective to make us more Christlike! Then when we get older and suffering is only making us more like the Lord and getting us closer to the goal. And so we can endure it with the confidence of Paul: “I have desire to depart and to be with Christ, which is far better.” (Phil. 1:23)

When we start thinking of it that way, then Scripture’s going to come alive.

Peter wrote to suffering saints:

1 Peter 4:12, 13

Beloved, think it not strange concerning the fiery trial which is to try you, as though some strange thing happened unto you. But rejoice inasmuch as you are partakers of Christ’s sufferings, that when His glory shall be revealed, you can be glad also with exceeding joy.

In the Sermon on the Mount Jesus said:

Matthew 5:11, 12

Blessed are ye when men shall revile you and persecute you and shall say all manner of evil against you falsely for my sake. Rejoice and be exceeding glad, for great is your reward in heaven.

The picture we have here is a picture of some people that are contending for their lives right there in the coliseum to

entertain the crowds, as these Christians become meat for hungry animals.

We don't paint that picture much today but it's there.

That brings us to our KEY VERSE—verse 29.

v. 29 Because to you it has been given in the behalf of Christ, not only to be believing on Him, but also to be suffering in His behalf,

“Because to you it has been given in the behalf of Christ, not only to be believing on Him, but also to be suffering in His behalf,”

Those are all in the PRESENT TENSE. This is not believing in the past. It's not suffering in the past. This is right now!

The picture he describes is that once we come to know Christ, it's not only believing on Him but also, right now, continually “be suffering in His behalf.”

Here are a few verses as we get ready to build on the premise.

1 Peter 4:1

Forasmuch then as Christ suffering in the flesh, arm yourselves also with the same mind.

Christ suffered. Do we expect to get it any easier than Him?

1 Thessalonians 3:3, 4

So that no man may be disturbed by these afflictions, for you yourselves know that we have been destined for this. For indeed, when we were with you, we kept telling you in advance that we were going to suffer affliction. And so it came to pass, as you know.

“...not only to believe on Him, but also to suffer in His behalf”—the THIRD GOAL:

3. the SUFFERING of CHRIST.

Can we honestly say:

“Lord, do whatever is necessary in my life to make me more like Jesus”?

Do you have enough confidence in your heavenly Father that you can turn and look into His face because you know of His love and you're living for His glory so you can say:

“Lord, do whatever is necessary to make me more like Jesus.”

Colossians 1:24

Now I rejoice in my sufferings, for your sake, and in my flesh I do my share on half of His body (which is the church) in filling up that which is lacking in the

sufferings of Christ.

Did Paul suffer? Yes he did.

Did he know at the entrance of the whole thing that he was going to suffer? There on the Damascus Road the Lord asked him:

Acts 9:4

Saul, Saul, why are you persecuting Me?

Why did Jesus say that? Because every time a saint suffers, He suffers too.

When Saul was taking it out on Christians, the Lord was suffering.

He tells Ananias to go and knock on his door and tell him what great things he's going to suffer for the cause of Christ.

We read that overwhelming list in 2 Corinthians 11 of what he went through:

WHIPPED with the 39 stripes—at least 3 times,

BEATEN with rods twice,

SHIPWRECKED a number of times,

Twenty-four hours in the OPEN SEA,
HUNGRY and without food,
THIRSTY without drink,
exhausting VIGILS, and on top of that,
care and concern for all the CHURCHES.

We don't teach that because we'll get unpopular and we'll lose some people.

Shadrach, Meshach and Abednego realized that it was God's plan to go through the furnace. And if God didn't go with them, that's all right! They were going because it was permitted by God! It was part of His plan.

Acts 4:29

And now, Lord, behold their threatenings and grant unto Your servants that with all boldness we may speak Thy word.

“Lord, they're rumbling out there. I want You to notice that and take notice of it but give us boldness to keep on preaching.”

Martin Luther said:

“Here I stand; God help me.”
(source unknown)

Someone said:

Sacrifice is the ecstasy of giving the best we have to the
one we love the most.
(source unknown)

That’s what suffering’s all about.

1 Peter 2:20, 21

For what glory is it when you are buffeted for your faults
you take it patiently. But if when you do well and suffer
for it, you take it patiently, this is acceptable with God.
For even hereunto were you called because Christ also
suffered for us, leaving us an example that we should
follow in His steps.

Charlie Jones wrote a book called *Life is Tremendous*. It’s a
great book of businessmen. In it he said:

(Life is Tremendous by Charles Jones)

The mark of a man who is growing is his understanding that
things go wrong to make us more right. God never breaks a
man down with problems except to build him up. The wild
stallion may look beautiful on the mesa with his mane blowing
in the wind, but he isn’t much use until somebody breaks him

so he can pull a load or carry a rider. Neither is a person much good until he is harnessed to teamwork and disciplined to guidance. God trains a man so the man can run free. That's an old law. You can fight it but you can never change it. Imagine how superficial our lives would be if God didn't send circumstances that seemed disastrous for the moment but later proved enriching and meaningful.
(source unknown)

There it is. That's why suffering is a goal! It hurts to have our stubborn will broken. It hurts to have someone cut across our pride and say what we're living for isn't real, isn't lasting and isn't meaningful.

The problem is God always manages to cut away the things that hurt the most, doesn't He? It's when He's lopping those things off, and those are the very things He needs to lop off, it's an indication there's still life there and we're hanging on to it rather than letting it go.

Charles Swindoll in his book *Three Steps Forward and Two Steps Back* says:

(Three Steps Forward, Two Steps Back by Charles Swindoll)

Most Christians, I think, have really learned this lesson. How perfect Murphy's Law really is for the believer.

Whatever will go wrong; will go wrong.
Going from bad to worse.

Out of the frying pan, and into the fire.

Between a rock and a hard place.

He said, Cheer up. Things could be worse. So cheered up,
and sure enough, they got worse.

My mother told me there would be days like this. But she
never said they would come in bunches.

(source unknown)

Then he tells this story:

(Three Steps Forward, Two Steps Back by Charles Swindoll)

So go the familiar expressions of exasperation. Tough days—we all have them. Some are worse than others. Like the one the hard-hat employee when he tried to be helpful. Maybe you read about this too. He was bruised and he was bandaged, he reported this experience:

When I got the building, I found that the hurricane had knocked off some bricks around the top. So I rigged up a beam with a pulley at the top of the building and I hoisted up a couple of barrels full of bricks. When I had fixed the damaged area, there were a lot of bricks left over. Then I went to the bottom and I began releasing the line. Unfortunately, the barrel of bricks was much heavier than I was. And before I knew what was happening, the barrel started coming down, jerking me up. I decided to hang on, since I was too far off the ground by then to jump; and halfway up, I met the barrel of bricks coming down fast. I received a hard blow on my shoulder. I then continued to the top, banging my head

against the beam, getting my fingers pinched and jammed in the pulley. When the barrel hit the ground hard, it burst its bottom, allowing the bricks to spill out. I was now heavier than the barrel, so I started down against at a high speed. Halfway down I met the barrel coming up fast, and received severe injuries to my shins. When I hit the ground, I landed on the pile of spilled bricks, getting several painful cuts and bruises. At this point, I must have lost my presence of mind, because I let go of my grip on the line. The barrel came down fast, giving me another blow on my head and putting me in the hospital. I respectfully request sick leave.
(source unknown)

That's the way it is sometimes.

Hebrews 5:8

Though he were a son, yet learned he obedience by the things which he suffered.

Psalms 119:67, 71

Before I was afflicted, I went astray, but now have I kept Thy word...It is good for me that I've been afflicted, that I might learn Thy statutes.

We're going to meet a lot of people in heaven who have learned the basic principle. God uses suffering to ripen and beautify Christian character and experience.

Adoniram Judson was called of God to Burma. After 14 years in that land, he could take you to the spot where his wife and all of his children lay, who were taken in death. He can tell you of imprisonments and diseases to his own body. But listen to what he says:

If I had not felt certain that every additional trial was ordered by infinite love and mercy, I could not have survived my accumulated sufferings.
(source unknown)

Is he ready to call it quits and go home in death? Far from it, for at this very time he prays that he might live to translate the entire Bible into the native language and to preside over a native church of at least 100 members.

That's what we're talking about; a willingness to pay the price.

Corrie Ten Boom said it well:

Surrender to the Lord is not a tremendous sacrifice, not an agonizing performance. It's the most sensible thing you can do.
(source unknown)

John Newton said:

Lord, we expect to suffer here, nor would we dare repine.
But give us still to find Thee near. And own us still for Thine.

Let us enjoy and highly prize these tokens of Thy love.
'Til Thou shalt bid our spirits rise, to worship Thee above.
(source unknown)

Job 13:15

Thou he slay me, yet will I trust in Him.

The problem is, when we start to suffer we get a wrong idea.
We miss what God is doing.

William Barker wrote a book called *When God Says No*. He was a Presbyterian minister and he takes all the passages where God said “No.” He tells this story:

(When God Says No by William P. Barker)

There's an old sea tale of a sole survivor of a shipwreck who was cast up on an uninhabited island. After anxiously praying to God for deliverance, he painstakingly collected whatever he could salvage from the wreck. With pieces of the wreckage he constructed a crude little hut and stored his few bits of valuables that he had saved. Every day he scanned the horizon for a sign of a passing vessel which he could hail. God seemed to have abandoned him, however, he cited nothing. One day when he returned from a search for food, he discovered that his hut was in flames. Everything was destroyed. The worst had happened, and his situation was hopeless. Angrily, the seaman cursed God. The next day, however, a ship arrived. The captain said, “We saw your

smoke signal, that's the reason we came."
(source unknown)

Too many times we do that.

With Jacob we can rail at them and say "All these things are against me! Joseph is no more! Simeon is no more! And you want to take Benjamin! Over my dead body! You'll not have him."

God's blessing is in giving up Benjamin, then God's going to work.

2 Corinthians 4:16, 17

For this reason we are not discouraged; but even though our outer nature suffers decay, our inner self is renewed day after day. For this slight, momentary trouble is producing for us an everlasting weight of glory that exceeds all calculation.

If we get a right concept of suffering and we make it our goal then when we get old and the outward body starts to fall apart. The inner man can be renewed daily!

Minnie Pearl, when she was describing aging, said:

I washed my face and forgot to iron it.
(source unknown)

That's the way we feel as the wrinkles come on.

1 Peter 1:6, 7

Be cheerful on this account, although now for a little while, if it must be you are distressed by various trials so that your tested faith, far more precious than perishable gold that is tested by fire, may prove to be to the praise and the glory and the honor, when Jesus Christ is revealed.

When we suffer we have to realize two things:

1. God is SOVEREIGN—don't ever lose that. What hit our life did not pass Him with surprise.

You never see God in the Bible say, "Bloop! I missed it! I didn't mean for that to happen." But we act like that. We think that God lost it so it hit us and it hurts.

We have to release one more thing:

2. God has a PURPOSE for all of us—He can work it out wonderfully.

He uses suffering to produce Christian character.

Now you see why these faith healers can be so upsetting? What right does an arrogant faith healer have to stand up and say "Exercise your faith and be whole!" If God is using that as

a tool to bring out Christlike character, it's totally contrary.

When you see people like Joni Eareckson Tada, Chuck Colson, Tim Hansel and Gail MacDonald you realize that they're entrusted with some of the deepest things and hurts that all of us could feel. Before God really trusts someone with significant ministry, He breaks their heart. They hurt, but they rise above it.

v. 30 having the same struggle which you saw in me, and now you are hearing to be in me.

“having the same struggle which you saw in me, and now you are hearing to be in me.”

Paul says it isn't easy. It's going to be a struggle. It's going to hurt.

Go with Jesus into the Garden of Gethsemane as He sweats great drops of blood and He agonizes over resisting the cup and the cross. That's what it is.

How do we adopt the goal of suffering in our own life?

1. **ACCEPT IT.** Have that attitude of acceptance. Take it, whatever it is, knowing the Father has a reason.
2. **HAVE A POSITIVE ATTITUDE.** Know just because of the reputation of our Father that something good is going to

come out of this and our actions declare it so as we can anticipate the victory.

The coach always picks the best players to play the toughest games and frankly that's where we should want to be.

One guy said it so well:

Life ain't no ride on no pink duck.
(source unknown)

It's tough.

Philips Brooks used to pray this way:

(I'm Running to Win by Ann Kiemel)

Lord, by all Thy dealings with us, whether of joy or pain or light or darkness, let us be brought to Thee. Let us value no treatment of Thy grace simply because it makes us happy or because it makes us sad, because it gives us or denies us what we want. But may all that Thou sendest us bring us to Thee, that knowing Thy perfectness, we may be sure in every disappointment that Thou art still loving us, and in every darkness that Thou art still enlightening us, and in every enforced idleness that Thou art still using us. Yea, in every death, that Thou art still giving us life. As in His death, Thou didst give life to Thy Son, our Savior Jesus Christ our Lord.

Amen

(source unknown)

There are a number of lessons that come out of our text.

Lesson #1: The practice of our lives ought to match the profession of our lips.

Lesson #2: Defensively, we are to stand firm and offensively, we are to contend.

Lesson #3: We are not to be frightened by our opponents.

Lesson #4: Salvation comes from God in response to our act of faith in receiving His Son.

Lesson #5: Suffering is part of the divine curriculum for our spiritual development.

Lesson #6: The suffering and struggling are making us more like our Savior.

The hymn writer said:

*Must I be carried to the skies
on flowery beds of ease
While others fought to win the prize
and sailed through bloody seas.*

(source unknown)

When a man comes back to God in the midst of suffering and then realizes he's being called upon to dig a little deeper.

That's called GUT-CHECK Christianity.

We're going to face a lot of things in our life that's going to bring stress and suffering, but we'll hang in there and we keep going. God is going to be faithful. He's going to carry us through.

God is always at His best when life is at its worst. We can count on that.

Just like Stephen, when the stones are pelting down, he sees heaven open and the Son of God standing on the right hand of the Father.

One writer put it this way:

Faith stands in the midst of suffering and sees the glory.
(source unknown)

Hang onto that.

Father, we can look beyond the present circumstances in our lives and see the glory, if by faith we do it. Thank You that Abram did not stagger in unbelief at the promises of God at a difficult time when You hadn't given him a child; but that in faith he could look beyond and see that glorious day of provision. Teach us in the midst of the arena of suffering to be those who contend together, living as citizens worthy, but recognizing that the tool of suffering is designed and forged in

the furnace of affliction, that we might be more Christlike. Rather than resisting, we'd respond to whatever You're allowing into Your divine, infinite purpose. Thank You that one day You will unroll the canvas and show us the reason why, but right now You only want us to trust You and to believe that You know what is best in each of our lives. We commit ourselves afresh to You this day with a better understanding of what Your purpose is in human suffering. In Jesus' name we pray. Amen.

A Practical Study of PHILIPPIANS

THE GOAL OF CHRISTIAN LIVING “Important Keys to Successful, Fulfilled Living”

GOAL NUMBER THREE – THE SUFFERING OF CHRIST – PHILIPPIANS 1:27-30

KEY VERSE 1:29

v. 27 Only live as citizens in a manner worthy of the gospel of the Christ; in order that whether having come and having seen you or whether being absent, I am hearing things concerning you, that you are standing firm in one spirit, contending with one soul for the faith of the gospel;

v. 28 and in no way being intimidated by your opponents, which is to them clear evidence (proof) of utter destruction, but of your salvation, and this from God.

v. 29 Because to you it has been given in the behalf of Christ, not only to be believing on Him, but also to be suffering in His behalf,

v. 30 having the same struggle which you saw in me, and now you are hearing to be in me.

NOTES

QUESTIONS:

1. Read Philippians 1:27-30 and in your own words pull out the main thought of this passage.

2. What does Paul ask them to do in verse 27?

3. What do you think it means to “stand firm in one spirit”?

4. How could we contend for the faith of the Gospel?

5. What is their attitude supposed to be toward those who are opposing them, according to verse 28?

6. Explain “utter destruction” and “salvation” in verse 28.

7. What two things are they supposed to do, according to verse 29?

8. Have you ever had to suffer for Christ? How?

9. Which verse in the study has meant the most to you?

10. What lesson have you learned from this study?

LESSONS FROM THE PASSAGE:

What are some of the lessons we can learn from this particular study?

LESSON #1: The practice of our lives ought to match the profession of our lips.

LESSON #2: Defensively, we are to stand firm and offensively, we are to contend.

LESSON #3: We are not to be frightened by our opponents.

LESSON #4: Salvation comes from God in response to our act of faith in receiving His Son.

LESSON #5: Suffering is part of the divine curriculum for our spiritual development.

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